

Design Rationale — Leadership Portfolio Redesign

DeepThought PM Internship Assignment • Part A Submitted by: Yash

What I Built

A working HTML/CSS prototype of the Leadership Portfolio page, using the exact mock data provided (`mock-portfolio-data.json`) and staying strictly within the fields defined in (`data-model.ts`). No invented data.

The prototype can be opened directly in any browser. No build steps, no dependencies.

Core Design Decision: Editorial Over Dashboard

The assignment brief is explicit — the portfolio should feel like a **pitch deck**, not a **dashboard**. My interpretation of this:

A pitch deck has one job: tell a coherent story in a linear reading order. A dashboard has one job: let you monitor many metrics simultaneously. These are opposite design goals.

So my layout is **vertical and linear**, not a grid. You read it top to bottom. Every section answers one question before the next one appears. The employee is the protagonist of the document — not a data subject being monitored.

The 5 Design Challenges I Addressed

Challenge 1: The Signal (most important)

Decision: A human sentence as the signal, anchored by a composite score ring — not metric soup, not a grade.

Why: The brief noted that Experiment 2's sentence still "felt like a stat readout, not a story." My solution: the sentence leads with an *event* ("breakthrough on the validation protocol that had been stuck for three months"), not a number. The number (71/100) sits beside it in a score ring for those who want a quick quantitative anchor — but it is secondary to the sentence.

Tradeoff: A sentence is harder to scan at a glance than a score or grade. I accepted this tradeoff because the brief's goal is a document you *read*, not a metric you *check*.

Challenge 2: Story vs Data Ordering

Decision: Narrative leads in every section, data follows as supporting evidence.

Why: The primary audience is the employee themselves, reading their own month. For them, the numbers only make sense with context — what does 80% delivery rate *mean* for this month specifically? The narrative paragraph provides that meaning before the number appears.

Tradeoff: Supervisors who want numbers first will need to read past the paragraph. I chose not to build a "supervisor mode" toggle — the brief says to pick a clear position, and I chose employee-first.

Challenge 3: Six Sections — Too Many?

Decision: Six sections retained, but structured in two tiers. Sections 1–3 are always fully visible (identity, signal, two story cards). Sections 4–6 are collapsed by default with a summary line visible.

Why: The two story cards (Contribution + Capability) carry 80% of the meaning for the employee. The evidence sections (KPIs, Constraints, Career) are important but not what you need to read every time. Collapsed by default means the page is readable in 60 seconds, expandable in 3 minutes.

Tradeoff: Users who *do* want KPI detail first have to click to expand. Acceptable — this is a monthly document, not a daily ops tool.

Challenge 4: The Constraint Section — Honesty Without Anxiety

Decision: Renamed "Constraint Patterns" → "**What Shaped This Month**". Constraints shown as individual items with type context and resolution status, not a complaint list.

Why: The word "constraint" is internal jargon and frames blockers as the employee's problem. "What Shaped This Month" reframes them as professional context — things that any competent person would document and navigate. The resolution status (✓ Resolved / ● Open) makes it clear which are closed chapters and which are ongoing — this is honest without being anxious.

Tradeoff: Less specific than "Constraint Patterns" in terms of jargon signal. But the brief explicitly says "no jargon in the UI" and "the audience is the employee and potentially their mentor — not a developer."

Challenge 5: Portability and Identity

Decision: Name, role, program, organization, and month are all in the header — prominent. The UID (PDGMS-EMP-00512) is in both the header and the footer. The footer also has the portfolio ID.

Why: The brief says "it needs to make sense outside the organization's context" I removed all

Why: The brief says "It needs to make sense outside the organization's context." I removed all PDGMS-internal jargon from visible labels: "IP Commits" → "Original Work Items", "Rituals" → "Engagement", "QA Passed" → "Delivered", "axis scores" → named axes with plain English labels.

Tradeoff: V-levels (V1, V2, V3) are retained as labels on the career runway — they're part of the career ladder system and can't be fully abstracted without losing meaning. I added plain English context ("Currently V2 → targeting V3") wherever V-levels appear.

Data Fidelity — What Maps Where

Every visible number in the prototype traces to a specific field in the data model:

UI Element	Data Source	Field
Score ring (71)	<code>executive_summary.data.compositeScore</code>	Section 1
Score delta (↑7)	Computed: <code>71 - 64</code> (previousMonthScore)	Section 1
Pace (Ahead)	<code>executive_summary.data.paceStatus</code>	Section 1
Deliverables (16/20)	<code>contribution_highlights.data.completed / totalDeliverables</code>	Section 2
IP count (7)	<code>contribution_highlights.data.ipCommitCount</code>	Section 2
IP list items	<code>contribution_highlights.data.recentCommits</code>	Section 2
Axis scores (80, 85, 74, 68, 58, 52)	<code>capability_growth.data.*</code>	Section 3
V3 threshold line (60)	Implied by <code>gapDrivers</code> text in section 6 data	Section 3
KPI rows	<code>kpi_impact.data.details[*]</code>	Section 4
Constraint counts (8/5/3)	<code>constraint_patterns.data.totalConstraints / resolved / open</code>	Section 5
Constraint items	<code>constraint_patterns.data.topConstraints</code>	Section 5

Career milestones	<code>career_trajectory.data.milestones</code>	Section 6
Projected date (Feb 2027)	<code>career_trajectory.data.projectedDate</code>	Section 6
Gap drivers	<code>career_trajectory.data.gapDrivers</code>	Section 6

What I did NOT show: Timesheet/hours data — it exists in `monthlyReportEnrichment.timeDistribution` but is not part of the portfolio endpoint per the brief's "What Does NOT Exist" table. I did not invent data the backend doesn't serve to the portfolio page.

What I Would Do Differently With More Time

- A real "supervisor view" toggle** — same data, numbers-first ordering. The brief notes supervisors want data first; one toggle could serve both reading modes without separate pages.
- Week-by-week sparkline** — the `weeklySummaries` array exists in the monthly report enrichment. A mini sparkline on the signal block would show whether the month was front-loaded, back-loaded, or consistent — meaningful context that's lost in a monthly aggregate.
- Comparison to previous months** — the `CareerRunrateSnapshotEnriched` type has `delta` and `deltaDirection` for each historical snapshot. A 3-month trend line per axis (not just the current score) would show trajectory, not just a single point.
- Narrative quality improvement** — the narratives in the mock data are well-written. In production, if narratives are AI-generated server-side, they need quality guardrails. The design assumes good narrative quality; weak narratives would hurt the pitch-deck feel significantly.
- PDF export** — since this is a portable career artifact, a "Export as PDF" action would make the document genuinely useful outside PDGMS.

Assumptions Made

- The V3 threshold for all axes is 60, based on the `gapDrivers` text in the mock data. The data model has `LevelCriteria.minScore` per axis per level, but the mock data doesn't include the full ladder definition — so I used 60 as the threshold for all axes (consistent with what's written in the narrative).
- Employee avatar is null in the mock data — I used initials (RI) in a colored circle instead.

The design supports a real photo if `avatarUrl` is populated.

3. The "3 months ahead of plan" figure is computed from `projectedDate` (Feb 2027) vs the planned milestone `targetDate` (May 2027) — a 3-month difference. This is displayed in the career stats row.
4. The career runway nodes are positioned proportionally across the full V1→V5 timeline (Aug 2024 → Aug 2036), not to linear scale — this is a visual simplification for readability.

Prototype file: `leadership-portfolio.html` — open directly in browser, no server needed.